

Golden Hour: Venue, Money, Date

Working logistics brief – with a verdict on each open decision

v1 · 2026-09-18 · prepared for Yatu

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The concept brief (2026-09-14) settled the *what*. This one is the *where, when, how much* – with a verdict on each so there's something concrete to disagree with.

1 · Venue — verdict: Asilomar Conference Grounds

The three-nights format changed the question. A one-evening event just needs a good west-facing room; a residential gathering needs a **campus**: everyone sleeping, eating, and watching the sky in one place, with no cars between the talks and the water. That points hard at one venue.

Asilomar Conference Grounds, Pacific Grove (Monterey Peninsula) – recommended.

- On the dunes of **Asilomar State Beach**, west-facing, the sun truly sinks into open Pacific. A boardwalk from the meeting halls to the sand: the nightly "walk to the water" is literally built.
- **Purpose-built for exactly this**: a residential conference grounds since 1913, Julia Morgan architecture, ~300 rooms, meeting halls with fireplaces (grey-day contingency built in).
- **All-inclusive per-person packages** – lodging + three meals + meeting space in one price: roughly **\$215/person/night double, \$320 single** at current rates. Budget below uses these.
- **Accidentally on-brand**: rooms have no TVs and famously spotty cell service. "No clocks in the venue" is halfway done before we hang the sunset dial.
- Travel: Monterey airport (MRY) 15 min away with direct flights from SF/LA/Denver/Dallas/Phoenix; SFO/SJC ~2h by chartered coach – one bus pickup, everyone arrives together.
- Risks to check on a site visit: late-Sept fog behavior on that exact beach; where the fire circle can legally burn (state park rules – likely the grounds' fire pits, not the sand); whether a ~100-person block clears their group minimums for equinox week 2027.

Runner-up: Scripps Seaside Forum, La Jolla. The best west-facing *room* in California (~200 cap, ~\$5k/day, glass wall to the water), and San Diego has the warmest, clearest late-September evenings. But no lodging – the hundred would scatter into hotels each night, and Nº 001 becomes a conference with nice sunsets instead of three days lived together. Keep it on the list only if the residential format ever drops.

Wildcard if scale drops to ~60: full buyout of **Timber Cove Resort** (Sonoma coast, 46 rooms, cliff over open water) – more cinematic, more expensive per head, harder travel.

Rejected: NYC/East Coast (sun sets over land – the one non-negotiable fails), Cavallo Point (sunset lands behind the Marin hills, not water), Big Sur resorts (right sky, wrong price: \$2k+/night).

2 · Money — verdict: invitations, not tickets — but the seat has a price

Keep the /together promise intact: **you cannot buy your way in.** But once invited, the seat costs what it costs. Free would make it feel like marketing; a price makes it feel like the Serpentine. Three tiers:

- **Invited seat: \$1,200** – roughly at cost (three nights' lodging + all meals + the field guide + the blanket). Framed exactly that way: "your seat costs what it costs us."
- **Patron seat: \$3,500** – same seat, same blanket; the surplus funds the comps. Offered, never required, to the funders on the list. Expect 10-15 takers.
- **Comped: ~20 seats** – speakers, the cohort-candidate scholarships, anyone for whom \$1,200 is the reason to say no. Quiet, no separate badge.

Sponsors, on-theme and invisible-ish (2-3 × \$15-25k): a watch brand, Oura / Eight Sleep, a lighting company (Ketra/Lutron). They get seats and a line in the field guide, not a banner.

Budget sketch (100 people, 3 nights)

LINE	EST.
Asilomar package (100 × 3 nights, ~\$260 avg incl. meals + meeting space)	~\$80-100k
Production & design: field guide print, blankets, sunset-dial commission, signage, phone pouches	\$20-30k
Speaker travel support (~10 people)	\$10-15k
Coach charters, photography, insurance, staff, contingency	\$15-20k
Total	≈ \$130-165k

Cover: 70 invited seats (\$84k) + 12 patrons (\$42k) + sponsors (\$40k) ≈ **\$166k**. It balances without needing to be a business – which is the right posture for N° 001.

3 · Date — verdict: Thursday Sept 23 – Sunday Sept 26, 2027

The equinox instant is **Sept 23, 2027, 06:01 UTC – Wednesday Sept 22, 11:01pm on the Pacific coast**. So autumn begins overnight Wednesday, and **Thursday evening is the first sunset of autumn**. That's the story:

- **Thu Sept 23 – First Sunset · Arrival.** "We arrive with the autumn." (the first sunset of the new season)

- **Fri Sept 24 – Second Sunset • The Conference.**
- **Sat Sept 25 – Third Sunset • The Cohort.**
- **Sun Sept 26 – depart at pastrise.**

Why this beats the alternatives:

- **Thu-Sun** is the long weekend /together promises; attendees burn one workday, not three (arrive-Wednesday would put the whole event midweek).
- **Late September is the Monterey coast's best sky:** the summer fog season is over, October-grade clarity, ~68°F days, sunset ≈ 6:55pm drifting a minute earlier each night – doors at ~3:00 tilset land mid-afternoon, dinner ends by 9. Civilized.
- **March equinox 2027 rejected:** sooner, but it's storm season on the California coast, cold on the sand at night, and it gives us only ~6 months of runway – not enough to book Asilomar or build the invite list properly.
- One honesty note for the site: the countdown currently targets Sept 22; retarget to **Sept 23** when this locks.

4 • Logistics runway (working backwards from Sept 23, 2027)

- **Now → Oct 2026:** Yatu picks coast + date (this doc's recommendations, or not). Send Asilomar the RFP for equinox week; site visit – watch one sunset from the boardwalk before signing anything. Confirm fire-circle rules and beach-event permit path (CA State Parks special event permit).
- **Nov-Dec 2026:** Contract + deposit. **The date locks here** – sunset tables get printed later and the sun won't renegotiate.
- **Jan-Feb 2027:** Invite list v1 (~150 names for ~80 non-comp seats). Speaker asks: two talks + the Golden Hour panel. Commission the sunset dial and the field guide design.
- **Mar 20, 2027 (spring equinox):** Invitations go out – *at the opposite equinox*, at each recipient's local golden hour. Applications route through the existing /together form.
- **May-Jun 2027:** Seats confirmed, patron conversations, sponsors closed. Cohort-selection method decided (who chooses the eight, and when they're told).
- **Aug 2027:** Field guide to print (sunset table now safely fixed). Coach charters, dietaries, weather contingency walk-through (Merrill Hall + fireplaces).
- **Sept 23-26, 2027:** Three sunsets.

5 • The three questions this leaves for Yatu

1. **Asilomar, yes or no?** (A site visit settles it – it's a 2-hour drive and one sunset.)
2. **Is \$1,200/at-cost the right seat posture**, or should N° 001 be fully funder-backed and free?
3. **Who picks the eight** – Yatu alone, a small committee, or the hundred themselves?

Sources

- Equinox timing: [timeanddate – seasons in UTC](#), [Wikipedia – September equinox](#)
- Asilomar packages & rates: [visitasilomar.com – Complete Meeting Packages](#), [CNCH 2025 rates](#), [ASMS lodging rates](#)
- Scripps Seaside Forum: [scripps.ucsd.edu – Seaside Forum](#), [Wedding Spot capacity/pricing](#)